



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 35

NEW YORK

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside New York's family courts and child-welfare system.

65

NEW YORK FAMILIES ON RECORD · 73
CHILDREN IMPACTED · 18 MONTHS
MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING
TIME

REPORT GENERATED
APRIL 26, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
24 OF 62

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

NEW YORK AT A GLANCE.

Across 65 New York families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 73 63 of 65 families reported child counts	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$10,000 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 18 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 36.9% 30.8% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 65	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.2	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 63 of 65	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 24

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so New York families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF NEW YORK FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	35	\$10,000	\$37,149	\$1,300,200
Lost Wages	34	\$14,250	\$85,918	\$2,921,199
Other Court Fees	20	\$0	\$3,275	\$65,500
Therapy / Evaluations	30	\$250	\$2,369	\$71,059
Reunification Services	25	\$0	\$3,458	\$86,450
GAL Fees	24	\$0	\$16,042	\$385,000
Asset Loss ¹	29	\$36,000	—	—
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$60,500	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$36,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		18	1.5 yrs
Mean months lost		35	2.9 yrs
Total across all families		1,282	106.8 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · NEW YORK

Most families documenting in New York are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Not provided		29	45%
Active case: stuck or delayed		21	32%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		9	14%
Case closed: within last 2 years		3	5%
I am not currently in court but still affected		1	2%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		30	46%
Unknown		17	26%
Family Court Only		14	22%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		2	3%
Family Court		1	2%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		10	15%
3 – 5 years		9	14%
Over 10 years		8	12%
5 – 10 years		8	12%
5+ years		7	11%

CUSTODY STATUS

50/50 Joint		17	26%
No Contact / Total Loss of Access		17	26%
Visitation Only		13	20%
Partial / Shared		5	8%
Children in Foster Care		4	6%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Erie		4	6%
Suffolk		3	5%
Chautauqua		2	3%
Genesee		2	3%
Jefferson		2	3%
Queens		2	3%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		18	28%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		9	14%
Family Court		7	11%
Other: (Short answer)		6	9%
Child Protective Services (CPS / DCF)		5	8%

05 PARENT VOICES — NEW YORK

Quotes appear as submitted. Long submissions are trimmed with [...] to fit the page; the full unedited quote is available in the online version of this report.



The child trafficking industry has ruined my life & my Special needs son landins life our family's life. Idk if we will fully heal from this trauma. We will work on it. As soon as we're allowed to. When landin is home. But until then. U cant heal in forced daily trauma & thats [...]

— JODI

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Ruined it. My kids cry for me, my ex lied, had admitted it and the courts do not care. Lost everything at one point and there is 0 evidence except he said she said.

— NEW YORK PARENT · AMANDA

MORE VOICES FROM NEW YORK

The system is beyond corrupted. It has caused nothing but trauma and devastation to me and the children.

— ANTONINA (ANTONELLA)

Has caused unfixable trauma to myself and my children. My 3 yr old has developed a blinking tick. He's had a complete behavioral change, sad crying saying no more daddy house. My one yr old is behind for talking, obsessive sucking of thumb. My 6 yr old foster son who I've had [...]

— MERRISA

My children's father has abused the kids and admittedly uses drugs, has abused and killed family pets, attempted to kill us, stalked me for years and my older children and now has sol custody due to court influences. I (mom) do not smoke, drink, or use drugs, I run an [...]

— NICOLE

2 petitions back to back with false allegations and a motion with 16 pages of false allegations and a cps report with false allegations and a call to my employer with false allegations....stolen time for my daughter and my relationship

— JASON

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



My ex and his attorney submitted false documentation to the court. The judge refused to allow my attorney to speak, while allowed my ex's attorney to speak at length, which set the tone. Marriage was clearly one sided and full of emotional and mental abuse. I am being forced to [...]

— OLIVIA

The court placed my now adult twin daughters with a known domestic abuser/sexual predator, leaving them at increased risk of harm, trauma, and poverty. I am being punished with false accusations because I dared speak about my trauma.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Judicially targeted, abused, misconduct, prejudice, domestic terrorists tried to off me.

— JIM

I'm a product of Westchester family court corruption. 4 years 8 months no trial, 3 fired lawyers, missed milestones, lies, and no relief.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Furthered the abuse and harm we were already facing. When the victims assistance center finally picked us up the night they took us to shelter I remember bawling my eyes out. At that point I had lost hope that there was any real chance at getting out of what we were living [...]

— LEEAH

Destroyed my family life & friendships. Left me homeless

— ANTONY

My abuser has been coddled and has been allowed to abuse me through the family court system not just me both my kid's as well.

— CRYSTAL

Cps has told the school not to release my kids to me on my court order parenting days despite doing everything they asked My ex is also telling my kids the state said there not allowed on my property.

— HEATHER M

My soon to be 6 year old son is being unlawfully concealed by a corrupt abuse of power within the Onondaga County NYS Family Court. The other party is related to local police. A preschool is also being investigated affiliated with my custody case.

— ASHLEY

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



They have made my other children hate me and are trying to take my child away now they have caused my family to have to live in fear

— MARGARET

Took my daughter away from me for 30 months when she was only 6 yrs old and she is now 9. A new referee presided over my case and my daughter was finally returned home October 2025, and we are still struggling to repair the damage that family court and CPS has done.

— ALYSSA

I was the only one caring and doing everything for my kids but they were ripped from me and it messed with them tremendously. My 10 yr old did not but cry my 4 yr old almost forgot who I was and I had no bond to my 3 month old.

— KIM

It has broken my family apart, cause immense psychological damage to my children, and forced me to close my business after 34 years

— STEVEN

My family was broken and financially devastated. I will never be able to recover because I am now paying my abuser

— MARK

It was traumatized my daughter and I, and has continued to have a negative impact on my life. After removing my daughter and placing her with her father-KNOWING HE HAS A HISTOY OF ABUSE & ORDERS OF PROTECTIONS AGAINST for my daughter and I, not long after my daughter was [...]

— RACHEL

They triggered my kids mental health purposely to make her unstable causing a mental health crisis that was turned around on me to take the blame. Lost housing services. My children were groomed into fearing me. loss of \$10k in personal belongings that was left behind

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They wanna press charges if my daughter doesn't go again to school because she was threatened by a student there if she near him he will do something bad and she is scared for her life to go back she feels unsafe and she showed the CPS evidence and they didn't care that she [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I have had a major part of who I am torn from me. The system stole my 5 kids. 14 years since I have struggled with this. I've been lost with no purpose. I wish someone would stop them from destroying families just for their gain.

— STACEY

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Bias. Never was questioned before about parenting and i was the primary caregiver. I was the favorite parent and he hated it (hates it)

— SAMANTHA

This system took so much time and the most formative years with my daughter from me. Time neither her or I will ever get back.

— NICOLE

Failed me and said they were doing it as the child's best interest but all I saw was a greedy system with an agenda

— CRISTIAN

Destroyed my faith in the system and greatly affected the relationship with my son for no good reason other than for money in someone else's pocket without fair due process

— JESSICA

The antiquated family court system is one of my initiatives for running for House of Representatives. I know god has handled my cases but I know that god appears to be missing from many.

— JESSICA

Just existing IS exhausting... I hide in my basement I don't go anywhere I don't have friends I don't have a job unfortunately just existing is all I can handle right now

— MARGARITA

Family court leveraged my child to financially drain me until I was forced into bankruptcy. I was then told I could not afford the defense to protect my daughter so I had to sign an unfavorable agreement or risk losing my parenting time.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has taken over 25 years the bond between a mother and her child time loss of the connection loss of special events holidays , birthdays graduation ceremonies Mother's Day and soso much more to meany to write down

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Ruined me in my child

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

33 New York parents submitted ranked quotes. 33 appear in this report; the remainder are available at standwithmeg.com/ny.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT**WHAT THIS IS**

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this New York report comes from New York respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in New York — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 65 New York families reporting here are not the universe of New York families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – April 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 5 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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